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THE BOOKINGS GAME

SPECTACULAR BOOKING NUMBERS ARE GREAT FOR PUBLICITY, BUT DO THEY GUARANTEE A SUCCESSFUL LAUNCH? IT'S COMPLICATED...



It may be easy to forget that the world's biggest electric car manufacturer was once teetering. Having made heavy investments to acquire Elon Musk's solar business and straddled with "production hell" for the Model X, things looked dicey. Till the bookings for the Model 3 kicked in. With nearly half a million bookings at $1,000 apiece, Tesla's books saw an influx of $500 million and it has never had to look back since.

The opening of bookings is a crucial milestone in the launch of a new car. It has always been so in India and, despite transformed market conditions with plenty of choices, it continues to be so. Not just a milestone, bookings have formed the cornerstone of the success of many auto companies here, including the biggest of them all. It all started with Maruti 800, which got over a lakh bookings when it was first launched, raising over half the investment needed to set up the plant to make the car. And then it got about one and a half lakh bookings when it underwent a generation change from the SS80 to the SB308.

That bookings record was obliterated with the nearly 3 lakh bookings for the Fiat Uno. The joint venture between PAL and Fiat failed despite raising over Rs 500 crore from the bookings for its first car launch. Then came the Tata Nano which also garnered over 2 lakh bookings, but could not translate the great interest into success.

Since then, there have been many great bookings success stories, including SUVs from the Korean sister companies, Hyundai and Kia. While Kia set a 50,000 bookings mark with both its SUVs and its latest offering, the Carens, Hyundai has gone further, with